# POST-GUPTA INDIA: HARSHA & EASTERN INDIA

**CHRONOLOGY AND EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE → POST-GUPTA POLITICAL LANDSCAPE → PUSHYABHUTI RISE AND KANNAUJ → HARSHA'S GRADED SOVEREIGNTY AND → ADMINISTRATION, REVENUE AND SAMANTA → EASTERN INDIA REGIONAL STATE**

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g2 • explicit approval of this exact generation is required • all prior artifacts unchanged

00

## STAGE 00 CHRONOLOGY AND EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE

CHRONOLOGY AND EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE · C. 550 CE · GUPTA CONCENTRATION WEAKENS; REGIONAL HOUSES MULTIPLY · 606 CE · HARSHA SUCCEEDS AMID THE RAJYAVARDHANA-RAJYASHRI CRISIS C. 630S · PULAKESHIN II CHECKS NORTHERN EXPANSION NEAR THE NARMADA · 637 CE · SHASHANKA DIES; EASTERN COMPETITION CONTINUES

c. 550 CE — Gupta concentration weakens; regional houses multiply → 606 CE — Harsha succeeds amid the Rajyavardhana-Rajyashri crisis c. 630s — Pulakeshin II checks → 637 CE — Shashanka dies; eastern competition continues → 647-648 CE — Harsha dies without a durable successor empire → SOURCES: Bana + Xuanzang + charters + coins + Aihole + archaeology

**CHRONOLOGY / PHASE**

- c. 550 CE → Gupta concentration weakens; regional houses multiply
- 606 CE → Harsha succeeds amid the Rajyavardhana-Rajyashri crisis c. 630s → Pulakeshin II checks northern expansion near the Narmada

**MATERIAL / INSTITUTION**

- 637 CE → Shashanka dies; eastern competition continues
- 647-648 CE → Harsha dies without a durable successor empire

**IMPACT / LIMIT**

- SOURCES: Bana + Xuanzang + charters + coins + Aihole + archaeology
- RULE: triangulate literary praise, pilgrim report and rival inscription.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — RULE: triangulate literary praise, pilgrim report and rival inscription.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: triangulate literary praise, pilgrim report and rival inscription.**

01

## STAGE 01 POST-GUPTA POLITICAL LANDSCAPE

POST-GUPTA POLITICAL LANDSCAPE · MAITRAKAS AND OTHER REGIONAL POWERS · MIDDLE GANGA · LATER GUPTAS + MAUKHARIS · PUSHYABHUTIS UNDER HARSHA · DECCAN LIMIT · BADAMI CHALUKYAS UNDER PULAKESHIN II · SEVERAL STRONG REGIONAL STATES REPLACED ONE UNCONTESTED IMPERIAL CENTRE.

NORTH-WEST / WEST → Maitrakas and other regional powers

MIDDLE GANGA → Later Guptas + Maukharis → THANESAR-KANNAUJ → Pushyabhutis under Harsha → GAUDA → Shashanka

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- NORTH-WEST / WEST → Maitrakas and other regional powers
- MIDDLE GANGA → Later Guptas + Maukharis
- THANESAR-KANNAUJ → Pushyabhutis under Harsha

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- GAUDA → Shashanka
- KAMARUPA → Bhaskaravarman
- DECCAN LIMIT → Badami Chalukyas under Pulakeshin II

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- VERDICT: several strong regional states replaced one uncontested imperial centre.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: several strong regional states replaced one uncontested imperial centre.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: several strong regional states replaced one uncontested imperial centre.**

02

## STAGE 02 PUSHYABHUTI RISE AND KANNAUJ SHIFT

PUSHYABHUTI RISE AND KANNAUJ SHIFT · STRONGER THANESAR LINE · RAJYASHRI + GRAHAVARMAN · MAUKHARI MARRIAGE BRIDGE · GRAHAVARMAN KILLED · RAJYAVARDHANA CAMPAIGNS · ACCESSION CRISIS · RESCUE + CONSOLIDATION + MAUKHARI INHERITANCE

PRABHAKARAVARDHANA — stronger Thanesar line → RAJYASHRI + GRAHAVARMAN — Maukhari marriage bridge → Grahavarman killed — Rajyavardhana campaigns — accession crisis → HARSHAVARDHANA — rescue + consolidation + Maukhari inheritance → THANESAR — KANNAUJ

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- PRABHAKARAVARDHANA — stronger Thanesar line
- RAJYASHRI + GRAHAVARMAN — Maukhari marriage bridge
- Grahavarman killed — Rajyavardhana campaigns — accession crisis

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- HARSHAVARDHANA — rescue + consolidation + Maukhari inheritance
- THANESAR — KANNAUJ
- MECHANISM: kinship + strategy + Ganga-doab access + sovereignty prestige

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- LIMIT: Harsha inherited a crisis, not a ready-made pan-Indian empire.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT: Harsha inherited a crisis, not a ready-made pan-Indian empire.**

03

## STAGE 03 HARSHA'S GRADED SOVEREIGNTY AND NARMADA LIMIT

HARSHA'S GRADED SOVEREIGNTY AND NARMADA LIMIT · DIRECT CORE · HARYANA, MUCH OF UP AND PARTS OF BIHAR · PROBABLE REACH · SELECTED EASTERN TERRITORIES INCLUDING ODISHA · WIDER ALLEGIANCE · KAMARUPA, VALABHI AND OTHER RULERS IN VARYING DEGREES · HARD LIMIT

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- DIRECT CORE → Haryana, much of UP and parts of Bihar
- PROBABLE REACH → selected eastern territories including Odisha
- WIDER ALLEGIANCE → Kamarupa, Valabhi and other rulers in varying degrees

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- HARD LIMIT → Pulakeshin II and the Narmada frontier
- BANA / XUANZANG → prestige-heavy northern view
- AIHOLE → rival Chalukya check

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- VERDICT: major north Indian hegemon; not a stable all-India emperor.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: major north Indian hegemon; not a stable all-India emperor.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: major north Indian hegemon; not a stable all-India emperor.**

04

## STAGE 04 ADMINISTRATION, REVENUE AND SAMANTA ORDER

ADMINISTRATION, REVENUE AND SAMANTA ORDER · MOBILE CAMP · BHUKTI PROVINCIAL UNITS · VISHAYA DISTRICT UNITS · OFFICERS, VILLAGES AND REVENUE COLLECTORS · SAMANTAS AND FEUDATORY RULERS · BHAGA + BHOGA + KARA + HIRANYA · ROYAL FORCES REINFORCED BY SUBORDINATE CHIEFS

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- KING / MOBILE CAMP
- bhukti provincial units
- vishaya district units

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- officers, villages and revenue collectors
- samantas and feudatory rulers
- REVENUE: bhaga + bhoga + kara + hiranya

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- ARMY: royal forces reinforced by subordinate chiefs
- TENSION: delegated reach could integrate territory and enlarge local autonomy.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TENSION: delegated reach could integrate territory and enlarge local autonomy.**

05

## STAGE 05 EASTERN INDIA REGIONAL STATE FORMATION

EASTERN INDIA REGIONAL STATE FORMATION · SHASHANKA, PUNDRAVARDHANA, SAMATATA, GOLD ISSUES · REGIONAL LINES, CHARTERS, AGRAHARAS AND EXPANDING SETTLEMENT · KAMARUPA, VARMAN LINE AND BHASKARAVARMAN · COMMON PROCESS · SANSKRIT CHARTERS + FISCAL DISTRICTS + MILITARY CAMPS LAND · CHRONOLOGY, ECOLOGY AND POLITICAL SCALE VARIED SHARPLY · DO NOT BEGIN EASTERN STATE HISTORY ONLY WITH THE

| POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY | EVIDENCE / MECHANISM | DEBATE / LEGACY |
|---|---|---|
| BENGAL / GAUDA — Shashanka, Pundravardhana, Samatata, gold issues | ASSAM — Kamarupa, Varman line and Bhaskaravarman | DIFFERENCE — chronology, ecology and political scale varied sharply |
| ODISHA — regional lines, charters, agraharas and expanding settlement | COMMON PROCESS — Sanskrit charters + fiscal districts + military camps land rights + agrarian expansion | RULE: do not begin eastern state history only with the Palas. |

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- BENGAL / GAUDA — Shashanka, Pundravardhana, Samatata, gold issues
- ODISHA — regional lines, charters, agraharas and expanding settlement

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- ASSAM — Kamarupa, Varman line and Bhaskaravarman
- COMMON PROCESS — Sanskrit charters + fiscal districts + military camps land rights + agrarian expansion

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- DIFFERENCE — chronology, ecology and political scale varied sharply
- RULE: do not begin eastern state history only with the Palas.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — RULE: do not begin eastern state history only with the Palas.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: do not begin eastern state history only with the Palas.**

06

## STAGE 06 LAND GRANTS AND AGRARIAN TRANSFORMATION

LAND GRANTS AND AGRARIAN TRANSFORMATION · CULTIVATED LAND + ROYAL CLAIM PURCHASE, CHARTER, BOUNDARY RECORD · RELIGIOUS BENEFICIARY CULTIVATION + LITERACY + FISCAL REALLOCATION + · EASTERN PLATES · LOCAL SCRIBES, MERCHANTS, LANDHOLDERS AND CULTIVATORS · ELITE CHARTERS REVEAL PROCESS MORE CLEARLY THAN PEASANT EXPERIENCE.

FALLOW / CULTIVATED LAND + ROYAL CLAIM purchase, charter, boundary record and tax remission → Brahmana / monastery / religious beneficiary cultivation + literacy + fiscal reallocation + landed hierarchy → EASTERN PLATES — local scribes, merchants, landholders and cultivators → LIMIT: elite charters reveal process more clearly than peasant experience.

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- FALLOW / CULTIVATED LAND + ROYAL CLAIM purchase, charter, boundary record and tax remission
- Brahmana / monastery / religious beneficiary cultivation + literacy + fiscal reallocation + landed hierarchy

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- EASTERN PLATES — local scribes, merchants, landholders and cultivators
- LIMIT: elite charters reveal process more clearly than peasant experience.

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- FALLOW / CULTIVATED LAND + ROYAL CLAIM purchase, charter, boundary record and tax remission
- Brahmana / monastery / religious beneficiary cultivation + literacy + fiscal reallocation + landed hierarchy

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT: elite charters reveal process more clearly than peasant experience.**

07

## STAGE 07 ECONOMY AND URBAN CHANGE DEBATE

ECONOMY AND URBAN CHANGE DEBATE · DECLINE EVIDENCE · CONTRACTION OF SELECTED OLDER TOWNS AND COIN CHANGES · REORGANISATION EVIDENCE · KANNAUJ RISES AS A STRATEGIC CENTRE EASTERN LAND WAS · ROUTES AND MARKETS PERSIST UNEVENLY · INSTITUTIONAL CONCENTRATION, NOT PROOF OF UNIVERSAL PROSPERITY · DECLINE IN OLDER FORMS COEXISTED WITH REGIONAL CREATION.

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- DECLINE EVIDENCE → contraction of selected older towns and coin changes
- REORGANISATION EVIDENCE
- Kannauj rises as a strategic centre eastern land was purchased with gold

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- in selected records new camps, grants, monasteries and regional capitals appear
- routes and markets persist unevenly
- NALANDA → institutional concentration, not proof of universal prosperity

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- VERDICT: decline in older forms coexisted with regional creation.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: decline in older forms coexisted with regional creation.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: decline in older forms coexisted with regional creation.**

08

## STAGE 08 RELIGION, ASSEMBLIES AND POLITICAL THEATRE

RELIGION, ASSEMBLIES AND POLITICAL THEATRE · EARLY LINE · SOLAR ASSOCIATIONS · SHAIVA IDIOMS · STRONG BUDDHIST PATRONAGE · KANNAUJ ASSEMBLY · DEBATE, HIERARCHY AND ROYAL DISPLAY · PRAYAGA ASSEMBLY

EARLY LINE — solar associations → HARSHACHARITA / CHARTERS — Shaiva idioms → XUANZANG — strong Buddhist patronage → KANNAUJ ASSEMBLY — debate, hierarchy and royal display → PRAYAGA ASSEMBLY — Buddha + Shiva + Sun across successive days

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- EARLY LINE → solar associations
- HARSHACHARITA / CHARTERS → Shaiva idioms
- XUANZANG → strong Buddhist patronage

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- KANNAUJ ASSEMBLY → debate, hierarchy and royal display
- PRAYAGA ASSEMBLY → Buddha + Shiva + Sun across successive days
- CHARITY → piety + redistribution + sovereignty performance

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- VERDICT: overlapping royal affiliations, not one exclusive religious label.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: overlapping royal affiliations, not one exclusive religious label.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: overlapping royal affiliations, not one exclusive religious label.**

09

## STAGE 09 NALANDA AND TRANS-ASIAN LEARNING NETWORKS

NALANDA AND TRANS-ASIAN LEARNING NETWORKS · LANDED SUPPORT · MONASTIC INFRASTRUCTURE · INDIAN TEACHERS <— NALANDA STUDY AND DEBATE <— ASIAN · STUDY, TRAVEL AND CARRIAGE OF BUDDHIST TEXTS TO CHINA · COMPARATIVE EVIDENCE AND NUMERICAL CAUTION · UNESCO SITE · SURVIVING VIHARAS, TEMPLES, ART AND PLANNED LAYOUT

ROYAL / LANDED SUPPORT → monastic infrastructure

INDIAN TEACHERS <— Nalanda study and debate <— ASIAN PILGRIMS → XUANZANG — study, travel and carriage of Buddhist texts to China → YIJING — comparative evidence and numerical caution

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- ROYAL / LANDED SUPPORT → monastic infrastructure
- INDIAN TEACHERS <— Nalanda study and debate <— ASIAN PILGRIMS
- XUANZANG — study, travel and carriage of Buddhist texts to China

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- YIJING — comparative evidence and numerical caution
- UNESCO SITE — surviving viharas, temples, art and planned layout
- SECURE CLAIM: major scholastic network

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- CAUTION: famous enrolment figures are estimates, not census data.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CAUTION: famous enrolment figures are estimates, not census data.**

10

## STAGE 10 SOURCE CRITICISM AND HISTORIOGRAPHY

SOURCE CRITICISM AND HISTORIOGRAPHY · ACCESSION AND COURT WORLD · LITERARY PRAISE · ELITE FOCUS · ROUTES, NALANDA, ASSEMBLIES · PILGRIM PURPOSE · LATER WRITING · OFFICES, GRANTS, TAXES

| BANA — accession and court world | literary praise / elite focus |
|---|---|
| XUANZANG — routes, Nalanda, assemblies | pilgrim purpose / later writing |
| CHARTERS — offices, grants, taxes | selective documentary survival |
| COINS — rulers, economy, symbols | circulation is not a border map |
| AIHOLE — Narmada limit | rival prashasti and exaggeration |
| SHARMA — structural transition | avoid universal decline |

**SOURCE / MATERIAL**

- BANA — accession and court world
- literary praise / elite focus
- XUANZANG — routes, Nalanda, assemblies
- pilgrim purpose / later writing
- CHARTERS — offices, grants, taxes

**METHOD / DEBATE**

- selective documentary survival
- COINS — rulers, economy, symbols
- circulation is not a border map
- AIHOLE — Narmada limit
- rival prashasti and exaggeration
- avoid universal decline

**HISTORICAL RESULT**

- SHARMA — structural transition
- avoid universal decline
- METHOD: claim — source — corroboration — limitation.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: METHOD: claim — source — corroboration — limitation.**

11

## STAGE 11 POST-GUPTA ANSWER SPINE

POST-GUPTA ANSWER SPINE · C. 550-750 AS CONTRACTION PLUS REGIONAL REORGANISATION · PUSHYABHUTI RISE + KANNAUJ + GRADED SOVEREIGNTY · PULAKESHIN II AND THE NARMADA · GAUDA + KAMARUPA + ODISHA/BENGAL GRANTS · SAMANTAS + LAND RIGHTS + AGRARIAN CHANGE · ASSEMBLIES + NALANDA + SOURCE TRIANGULATION · HARSHA BRIEFLY REUNITED THE NORTH WHILE REGIONAL STATES DEEPENED.

OPEN — c. 550-750 as contraction plus regional reorganisation → POLITY — Pushyabhuti rise + Kannauj + graded sovereignty → LIMIT — Pulakeshin II and the Narmada → EAST — Gauda + Kamarupa + Odisha/Bengal grants → STRUCTURE — samantas + land rights + agrarian change

**POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY**

- OPEN → c. 550-750 as contraction plus regional reorganisation
- POLITY → Pushyabhuti rise + Kannauj + graded sovereignty
- LIMIT → Pulakeshin II and the Narmada

**EVIDENCE / MECHANISM**

- EAST → Gauda + Kamarupa + Odisha/Bengal grants
- STRUCTURE → samantas + land rights + agrarian change
- CULTURE → assemblies + Nalanda + source triangulation

**DEBATE / LEGACY**

- CLOSE → Harsha briefly reunited the north while regional states deepened.

**ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE — Harsha briefly reunited the north while regional states deepened.**

E

## EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · POST-GUPTA INDIA · HARSHA & EASTERN INDIA — ADVANCED · 1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA · 2. KEY CLASSIFICATION · 3. STUDY LINKS · 4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS) · 5. UPSC TRAPS

**OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH**

- Post-Gupta India: Harsha & Eastern India — ADVANCED
- Mini-timeline
- 1. Snapshot & core idea
- 2. Key classification / data

**ADVANCED DEBATE**

- 3. Study links
- 4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)
- 5. UPSC Traps
- 6. Current link

**LEGACY / NUANCE**

- 7. Mains angles
- Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)
- The Pushyabhutis initially had their base around Sthanishvara/Thanesar .
- Harsha's reign involved military engagements; claims of success must be tested against rival records.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels